ERA 3

Colonial Society

1607 – 1754

Atlantic trade · slavery · self-government · the Great Awakening

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did the Atlantic economy, slavery, and new ideas reshape colonial society and plant the seeds of an American identity?

KEY TERMS

Mercantilism · Navigation Acts · salutary neglect · chattel slavery · slave codes · Great Awakening · Enlightenment

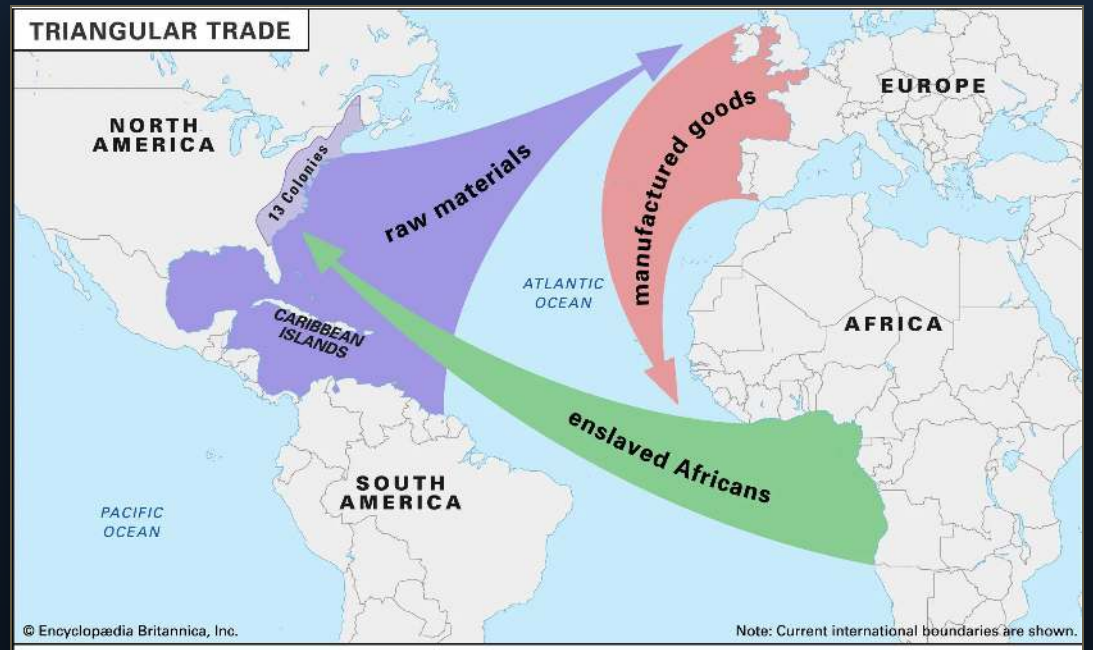
ALIGNED TO

CED Topics 2.4–2.7 · AMSCO Ch. 2.4–2.7

TRADE & MERCANTILISM

The Atlantic Economy

Triangular Trade



The Atlantic slave trade was part of a profitable network of commerce across the Atlantic Ocean. Goods and enslaved people were traded between Europe, Africa, and the Americas. This network is often called the triangular trade because it had three basic stages thatroughly form the shape of a triangle when viewed on a map.

- A three-way **Atlantic** trade linked the colonies, Africa, and Europe.
- Rum and goods went to Africa; enslaved people endured the **Middle Passage** to the Americas.
- Raw materials and cash crops flowed back to Europe.

The Logic of Mercantilism

I

Colonies Exist to Enrich

A nation's power depended on its wealth—and colonies fed the mother country.

II

Raw Materials Out

Colonies shipped raw materials to Britain and bought British manufactured goods.

III

A Favorable Balance

The goal: export more than you import, hoarding gold and silver.

Britain's Loose Grip

LAW

Navigation Acts

Britain restricts colonial trade to British ships and markets.

→

REALITY

Salutary Neglect

Distance and distraction mean loose enforcement.

→

RESULT

Colonial Autonomy

Colonists smuggle, self-govern, and grow used to independence.

ACCOMMODATION & CONFLICT

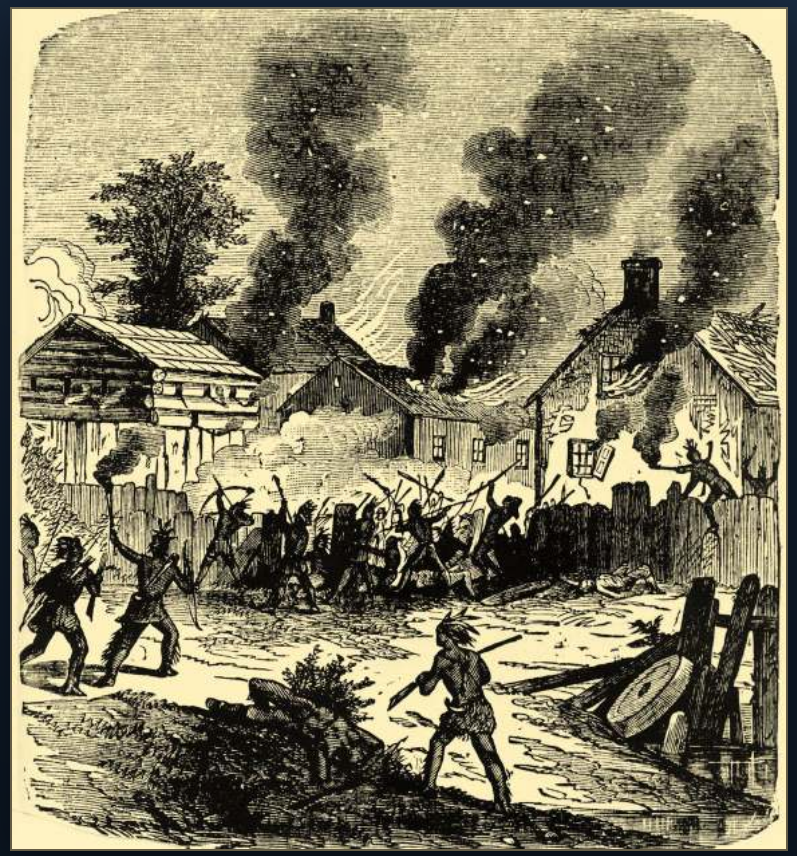
Natives & Colonists

Three Colonial Conflicts

Expansion and forced labor sparked resistance across the colonies

CONFLICT	WHERE	CAUSE	RESULT
King Philip's War	New England	Colonial expansion onto Native land	Colonists win; **Metacom** killed
Bacon's Rebellion	Virginia	Frontier farmers vs. **Berkeley** & Natives	Crushed; hastened shift to slavery
Pueblo Revolt	New Spain	Forced labor & religious suppression	Pueblos expel the Spanish for ~12 years

King Philip's War



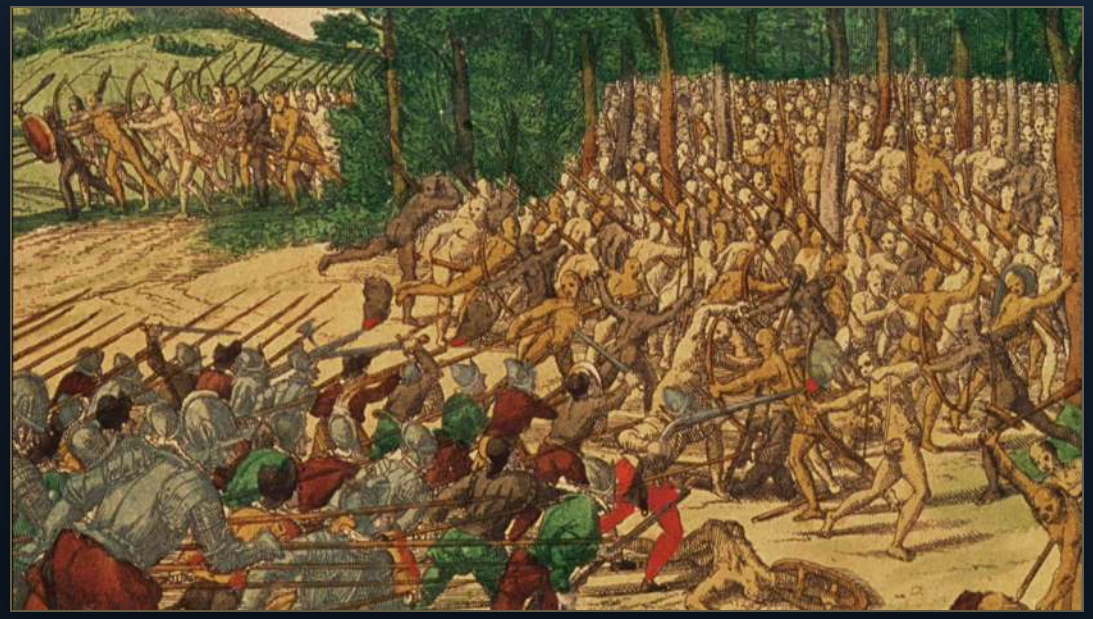
- **Metacom** (King Philip) of the **Wampanoag** united tribes against New England colonists.
- The war was brutal and bloody for both sides.
- Colonists won, and **Metacom** was killed—breaking Native power in the region.

Bacon's Rebellion, 1676

- Frontier farmers led by **Nathaniel Bacon** revolted against Governor **Berkeley**.
- They attacked Native villages and burned Jamestown.
- Fear of poor rebels helped push planters toward **enslaved**, rather than indentured, labor.



The Pueblo Revolt, 1680



- Pueblo peoples rose up against Spanish forced labor and religious suppression.
- They drove the Spanish out of New Mexico for over a decade.
- One of the most successful Native resistances in North America.

SECTION

Slavery in the Colonies

From Servitude to Slavery

DEMAND

Labor Shortage

Plantations need cheap, permanent labor.

→

SHIFT

Fewer Servants

Rising English wages shrink the supply of indentured servants.

→

TRIGGER

Bacon's Rebellion

Fear of armed poor whites pushes planters toward enslaved Africans.

→

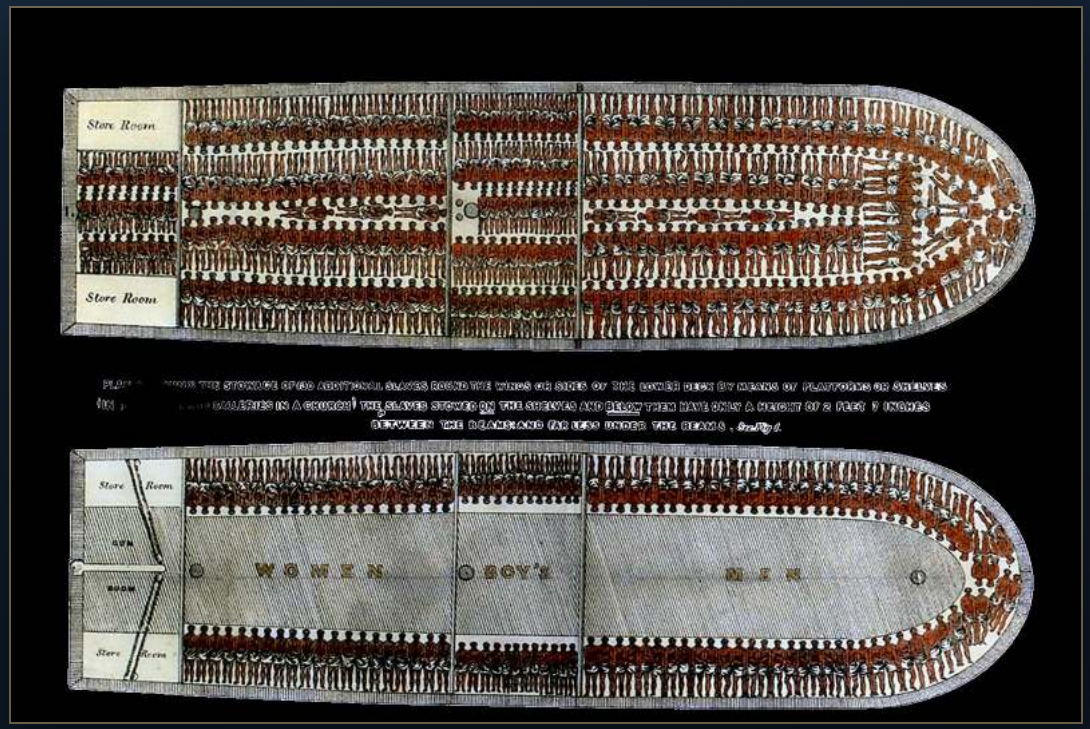
RESULT

Slave Codes

Laws make slavery lifelong, hereditary, and racial.

The Middle Passage

- Enslaved Africans were packed into ships bound for the colonies.
- Roughly 12 million endured the **Middle Passage**; many died at sea.
- By 1750 slavery was concentrated in the Chesapeake and Southern colonies.



Resistance to Enslavement

I

Everyday Resistance

Slowing work, breaking tools, and feigning illness.

II

Escape & Revolt

The 1739 **Stono Rebellion** in South Carolina was the largest colonial uprising.

III

Preserving Culture

Enslaved communities kept languages, religion, and family bonds alive.

SECTION

New Ideas in the Colonies

Two Movements Reshape Colonial Thought

The Great Awakening

A religious revival

- Emotional preaching by **Jonathan Edwards** & **George Whitefield**.
- Emphasized personal faith and spiritual rebirth.
- Split churches into '**New Lights**' and '**Old Lights**.'
- Weakened deference to established authority.

The Enlightenment

An intellectual movement

- Championed reason, science, and individualism.
- **John Locke**'s natural rights and social contract.
- Inspired thinkers like Franklin and Jefferson.
- Laid the intellectual groundwork for revolution.

The Great Awakening



- Revivals drew huge crowds to open-air preaching across the colonies.
- The movement crossed colony and class lines—an early shared 'American' experience.
- By loosening ministers' authority, it helped **democratize** colonial society.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Colonial Society

1. **Mercantilism** and the **Navigation Acts** bound the colonies to Britain—but **salutary neglect** let self-government and smuggling flourish.

2. Expansion and forced labor sparked resistance (**King Philip's War, Bacon's Rebellion, Pueblo Revolt**), and colonies hardened into **racial slavery**.

3. The **Great Awakening** and **Enlightenment** spread new ideas about faith, reason, and authority—seeds of an American identity.

DISCUSS & APPLY

Colonial Society

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how **Bacon's Rebellion** helped push colonial labor from indentured servitude toward hereditary, racialized slavery.

COMPARISON

Compare the **Great Awakening** and the **Enlightenment** as forces shaping colonial thought.

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did **salutary neglect** change the relationship between Britain and the colonies over time?

Up next — **Lesson 5: The Seven Years' War** (the road to revolution begins)